

Cape Verde



Off the west coast of Africa, in the Atlantic Ocean, lies the group of islands that make up Cape Verde, a Portuguese colony until it gained independence in 1975.



GEOGRAPHY

Ten main islands and eight smaller islets, all of volcanic origin. Mostly mountainous, with steep cliffs and rocky headlands.



CLIMATE

Warm, and very dry. Subject to droughts that can sometimes last for years at a time.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Most people are of mixed Portuguese–African origin; the rest are descendants of African slaves or more recent immigrants. Creolization of the culture negates ethnic tensions. Almost half of the population live on Santiago. Around 700,000 Cape Verdeans live abroad, mostly in the US.



INSIGHT: Poor soils and lack of surface water mean that Cape Verde is dependent on food aid



THE ECONOMY

Most people are subsistence farmers. Clothing is the main export. No natural resources. Mid-Atlantic location ensures work maintaining ships and planes.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Cape Verde

DATE OF FORMATION: 1975

CAPITAL: Praia

POPULATION: 505,600

TOTAL AREA: 1557 sq. miles
(4033 sq. km)

DENSITY: 325 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Creole, Portuguese*

RELIGIONS: Roman Catholic 97%,
other 2%, Protestant 1%

ETHNIC MIX: Mestiço 60%, African 30%,
other 10%

GOVERNMENT: Mixed presidential-
parliamentary system

CURRENCY: C.V. escudo = 100 centavos